

was not feasible till this time owing to the low capacities per chip and the cost per chip. Even now the cost per GB for SSDs is quite high compared to HDDs.

Software API

Now different operating systems and programs use different methods of utilising a sound card's prowess, there are separate APIs accepted as standard by game developers which make it easier to create special effects like 3D sound. The more APIs your sound card supports the more accurate reproduction of the intended sound it can accomplish.

Common APIs include:

1. Microsoft: DirectSound
2. Creative: Environmental Audio Extensions (EAX) and Open AL
3. Sensaura: MacroFX
4. QSound Labs: QSo

Onboard and discreet

The reason why you'll never have seen a sound card is that onboard sound CODECS have improved so much that certain low-end audio cards sound worse than onboard sound. They boast of significantly high SNR and are capable of driving quite a lot of mid-range headphones and speakers. Also since a good speaker system relies on an external amplifier so having one onboard doesn't make sense, especially given the extra power needed which your power supply might not be able to sufficiently provide.

Interface

Sound cards are either internal or external. Internal sound cards use the PCI or PCI express slots. A 1x PCI express slot is more than enough and there is usually one in almost every motherboard. Since the card connects directly to the motherboard there is less noise given the low latency and

